For its part, China retained suspicions that India was supporting Tibetan guerrillas. Rebellion had broken out among the Khampas of eastern Tibet in 1954 and began to spread. After 1956, the US Central Intelligence Agency provided training for Khampa rebels exfiltrated via India, East Pakistan, and Thailand, and also made arms and ammunition drops in Tibet. [91] The Dalai Lama visited India in 1956 and 1957 for Buddha Jayanti commemorations, and there were already calls by some of his supporters for him to remain there in the context of the spreading Tibetan revolt. Nehru urged the Dalai Lama to return and non-violently advocate for Tibetan autonomy. [92]

As the Tibetan situation worsened, so did discussions on the boundary and, coupled with concerns about the Dalai Lama, this prompted Zhou Enlai to fly twice to India in 1956 and 1957. In discussions with Nehru on these trips, Zhou referenced the McMahon Line, which Nehru interpreted as his acceptance of it. [93] But in September of 1957, India discovered that a road between Xinjiang and Tibet had been constructed through Aksai Chin. For China, this was strategically very significant as it could be used year-round to supply Tibet and was secure from the spreading Tibetan insurgency. The discovery should not have come as a complete shock to New Delhi: news and intelligence reports had pointed to its construction after 1952, but India only raised this in formal negotiations in October 1958. [94] While India was prepared to negotiate on Aksai Chin, where its claims were more tenuous, correspondence in 1958 and 1959 also indicated far more aggressive Chinese claims south of the McMahon Line in the eastern sector. [95] In the midst of all this, Nehru made a brief transit through Yadong—traversing some of the distance by pony and yak—on the way to Bhutan in September 1958. This made him the first national leader to visit Tibet since 1950 (his counterpart, Zhou, had not yet done so). [96]

After full-fledged rebellion broke out in Lhasa, the Dalai Lama sought asylum in India in the spring of 1959, followed by thousands of fleeing Tibetans. India also considered taking the Tibet issue to the United Nations but chose ultimately not to do so. [97] India’s position remained that Tibet was a part of China, but it justified its provision of shelter for the Dalai Lama